OTTOMAN ARMS

The armed forces of the Ottoman Empire in the 15th and 16th centuries were extremely diverse. Armoured cavalry equipped with sabre and shield were an essential element, alongside light horsemen, infantry with firearms, and artillery. The armour and weaponry shown here – such as mail-and-plate coats, curved swords, and round shields – are broadly similar to that found at the same period across a wide area of the Islamic world, including Safavid Persia and Mughal India.

Chichak (helmet)
Made entirely of plates – with additional face, neck, and ear protection – this 16th-century *chichak* afforded the Ottoman Empire cavalryman excellent protection. The inner-skull, ear pieces, and peak all retain the lining of wadded and quilted red fabric. The central band and neck guard are engraved with Koranic text.

Riveted pointed peak

Chain mail

Concave neck guard

Nose guard

Kite-shaped ear protector pierced for hearing

Rivet securing buckle

Zirh gomlek (mail-and-plate coat)
This Ottoman Empire body armour dates from the late 15th century. The coat is composed of both riveted and solid mail links with plates engraved with scrolling foliage. The translation of the inscription is "Power is in obedience. Wealth is in contentment. May the end be to the best".

Buckles and straps secure armour at front

Khanjar (dagger)
The design of this ivory-handled *khanjar*, with an area of unsharpened blade by the quillons, allowed the soldier to hold it low on the grip for greater control.

Rhinoceros-horn sword grip

Ivory grip

Quillons (finger guard)

Gold crosspiece

Silver gilt overlay

Koranic inscription

Gold inlay

Mail of cuirass showing Koranic inscription



Gilding on sword blade with inscription



Rear of *kalkan* showing hand grip

